



Fry's electronics shut down

After 36 years in business, the one-stop-shop permanently closes operations in the US due to COVID-19. <http://digit.in/mar21-03>



Facebook bans news in AU

Facebook announces that it will ban Australian users from sharing or viewing news on the platform. <http://digit.in/mar21-04>

reduce the dependency on third-party apps that allow one to do the same.

Improved audio

Android 12 brings with it support for MPEG-H in passthrough and offload modes, while audio mixers, resamplers, and effects can now bring 24 channels support. Apart from this, Android 12 also allows users to customise and select what media player appears in your Quick Settings section. So, you can essentially turn off

YouTube, Spotify, or other players in the quick settings, should you wish to. To do this, you need to long-press the media player notification and then you will be directed to the specific settings where you can turn off apps that you don't want showing up in Quick Settings. Alternatively, you can also manually go to Settings > Sound & Vibration > Media and turn off all the apps you want to ban from the media player in quick settings.

One-handed mode

While several OEM manufacturers have had their own iterations of one-handed mode, to tackle the problem of reachability with large smartphones, Google is finally bringing it natively to Android 12. As per a report by 9to5Google, the one-handed mode will compress the UI down vertically, making it easier to reach with one hand. The mode can also reportedly be turned on and off with a gesture.

Android updates via Google Play

As per reports, the Android Runtime (ART) will be added to Project Mainline, which is Google Play's system updates program. This will allow key updates to be pushed through Google Play Services itself, negating the need for full system updates for small tweaks. Google also mentioned that more module updates will be

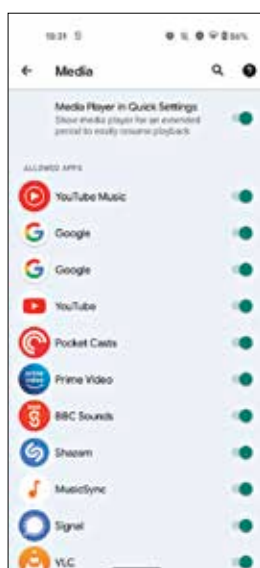


Image Source: 9to5Google

pushed through Project Mainline in the future, including transcoding improvements.

Haptic-coupled audio effect

With Android 12, Google is allowing developers to merge haptic feedback patterns with audio. The haptic-couple audio effect essentially will create vibrations in accordance with the audio playing at the same time from the device. Google says it will allow developers to create more immersive game

and audio experiences. The feature will allow users to pass on the vibration to connected game controllers, which sounds like a lot of fun!

Media

Android 12 will be capable of automatically transcoding HEVC and HDR videos recorded on devices to AVC, a format that is widely compatible with media players. This is useful for apps that don't or can't support the HEVC codec that many modern camera apps use. Android 12 also introduces support for images that use the AVIF (AV1 Image File Format). This format improves the image quality when compared to older formats such as JPEG while keeping the file size the same with better image compression.

RUMOURED FEATURES

Stackable widgets

According to Mishaal Rahman's tweet, Android 12 could feature something called 'expanded smart space' that looks a lot like iOS's widget stack feature. Google could be looking into the possibility of bringing up relevant widgets from the 'stack' based on the time of day, or some other parameter.

Smarter app storage management

This feature is already present in the Android Open Source Project (AOSP). Basically, the feature allows the OS

to clear an app's cache if it's labelled as 'hibernating', allowing for better memory management. So far, we don't know what constitutes a 'hibernating' app and if it is determined by the system or user. Nevertheless, if the feature does show up in Android 12, it could be a game-changer for entry-level Android devices or older devices.



App pairs

Similar to Samsung's App Pair feature on One UI, there are reports that Google has developed its own App Pairs feature that allows users to manage two opened apps in Android's recent menu as one task. This would particularly be great for larger devices, foldables, and tablets.

Restricted network mode

Reportedly, a reworked networking management mode could be present in Android 12 that gives the OS more control over which apps can use the internet. As per XDA, the feature will be toggleable in the OS, but it's unclear if the actual blocklist can be tweaked by the user.

Scrolling screenshots

Scrolling screenshots could finally be heading over to Android as a baked-in feature in Android 12. According to XDA, the code to make this happen is in the works.

Double-tap back gestures

Android 12 could come equipped with a nifty double-tap feature that could actually be enabled by Pixel users way back in the Android 11 Developer Preview. It allowed Pixel users to double tap the back of their device and assign a task to that action such as launching apps, taking a screenshot, etc. It's possible that this feature, while it never made it to the final Android 11, could return to feature in the final build of Android 12. 